Deep Study System

Goal: understand it deeply, explain it clearly, and use it. Built for starting easily and staying consistent.

START HERE (2 minutes): Open your notes. Write ONE session question. Set a 5 minute timer. You only have to last 5 minutes. Then decide: keep going or stop.

The whole system on one screen

Piece	What it is	Why it's here
Chunking	Break a topic into small pieces, each with one question	Makes starting less vague and fits one focus block
Active recall	Close the book, write what you remember	Shows what you actually know, and the retrieval itself strengthens memory
Spaced repetition	Re-quiz misses on Day 1, 3, 7, 21	Fights forgetting without cramming
Question framework	10 questions to go from surface to deep	Covers history, how, why, limits, use
Timers	40 min focus, 10 min recall, 10 min break	Takes the 'when do I stop' decision away

The loop

Step	Time	Do this
1. Setup	2 min	Write the session question. Phone out of reach. Timer on.
2. Focus	40 min	Study the chunk. Tangents go in the parking lot.
3. Recall + notes	10 min	Book closed. Write from memory. Then check and fix in a different color.
4. Break	10 min	Away from screens. Walk, water, stretch.
5. Close	2 min	List misses under **Gaps**. Say one idea out loud.

Tune it: 40/10 is a starting point. If 40 minutes is too long, use 25 min focus and 5 min recall. A shorter block you finish beats a long one you skip.

The 3 core techniques

1. CHUNKING (make it small enough to start)

What: split a big topic into pieces that each answer ONE question and fit one 40 minute block.
How: list the topic's parts, name each chunk with a question, pick one per session.
Example: 'Memory in C' becomes: What is the stack? / What is the heap? / What is a pointer? / How do stack and heap differ?
Rule: if you can't say what the chunk's question is, it's still too big.

2. ACTIVE RECALL (pull it out, don't re-read it)

What: test yourself instead of re-reading. Re-reading feels productive but mostly tricks you into feeling familiar.
How (10 min after each focus block):

1. Close the book and the tab.
2. Answer the session question on a blank page, from memory. Messy is fine.
3. Open the source. Fix and add in a **different color** (or after a divider).
4. Anything you missed or got wrong goes in **Gaps**.

Notes come AFTER recall, so your notes reflect what you actually learned.

3. SPACED REPETITION (revisit just before you forget)

What: review material at growing gaps instead of all at once.
How: quiz your Gaps list from memory on **Day 1, Day 3, Day 7, Day 21**. Quiz the questions, don't re-read the notes.
If you get it right: move to the next interval. **If you get it wrong:** add it back to Gaps and restart its schedule.
Missed a review day? Do it as soon as you can. Don't restart everything.
Optional: flashcard app (like Anki) if you want it automated. Plain markdown notes work too.

Drill the weak links

Test your notes: cover them, answer the questions, and mark what you got wrong. Drill ONLY those items. Don't spend time on what you already know.

The Question Framework

Run these on any concept. Answer from memory first. Concept: _____ Date: _____

UNDERSTAND (about 12 min)

1	**What problem does it solve? What did people do before it?**
2	**What is it, in ONE plain sentence?**
3	**How does it work, step by step?**
4	**[Why] Why does it work? What's the underlying reason?**
5	**[Fail] When does it break or stop applying? What fixes that?**

EXPLAIN (about 5 min)

6	**Can I explain it out loud with an example, no notes? [ ] yes [ ] no**
7	**What is it commonly confused with? How is it different?**

USE (about 3 min)

8	**[Use] Where does it show up in real systems or work?**
9	**How does it connect to my goal? What can I do or learn next?**
10	**Tradeoff: what does it cost vs. the alternative? (technical topics)**

Gaps to review later: _____

Can't answer a question? That's the gap. Write it down, look it up, then re-answer it from memory. Can't answer Q9? The concept may belong in the parking lot.

Getting Started

For studying and the boring stuff that MUST get done.

My setup (fill in once)

My cue (something I already do daily): After I _____, I open my notes.

My study spot: _____ **My study time:** _____

Night before: leave the note open with tomorrow's session question written in it.

The start ladder

Step	Do this
1. Cue fires	Do the same trigger action every time. Don't wait to 'feel ready'.
2. Set a 5 minute timer	You're only committing to 5 minutes.
3. Tiny first step	Open the note, write the session question, or gather the materials. That's it.
4. Timer rings	Decide: keep going or stop. Both count. Usually you'll keep going.

Boring must-dos (bills, forms, admin)

Ugly first pass: 10 minutes, no goal of finishing.
Write the next physical action, not the task: 'open the bank app,' not 'do budget.'
Do it before content (YouTube, Netflix, scrolling), not after.
Pair it: do it during a 25 min timer, then a small reward.

If-then plans (pre-decide the hard moments)

If this happens...	Then I...
I start debating whether to study	Set a 10 minute timer and start.
I get pulled into a tangent	Write one line in the parking lot, go back.
I feel stuck for 5+ minutes	Mark the question under Gaps and move on.
I miss a day	Do the 10 minute minimum tomorrow. Never miss twice.
I'm about to open a feed	Stand up, drink water, then start the timer.

Notes, Review, Tracking

Note template (copy into markdown)

```
# Concept: ________   Date: ______
## Session question
(one question this session answers)

## My answer (from memory)
...

## Corrections (different color / after divider)
...

## Gaps
- [ ] item     (review: D1 __ D3 __ D7 __ D21 __)

## Parking lot
- ...
```

Weekly reset (15 min, same day each week)

[ ] Drill this week's Gaps from memory
[ ] Pick next week's session questions (one chunk each)
[ ] Put sessions on the calendar and set alarms
[ ] List the must-dos and write each one's next physical action

Bad-day version

Minimum: 10 minutes. Do just Setup plus one recall. A tiny session still counts and keeps the chain alive.
Optional to test: body doubling (study alongside someone on a silent call or a timed study-with-me video). Try one session with it and one without, and compare how easy it was to start.

Tracker (one X per day, aim for a chain)

Week of	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Concept studied